WEBINAR SUMMARY REPORT

Webinar Title: Publishing with Confidence: Understanding Predatory Journals and the Value of Scopus

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Presenters

The session was led by the following excellent expert presenters:

- **Dr. Shubhra Dutta:** Senior Customer Success Manager at Elsevier.
- **Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna:** Epidemiologist, public health scientist, and Research Integrity and Certification Expert at Elsevier. She previously led the landmark Dutch National Survey on Research Integrity.
- **Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen:** Full Professor and Chair of the Soil Biology Group at Wageningen University, Netherlands. He also serves as the Subject Chair for Agriculture and Biological Sciences on the Scopus Content Selection & Advisory Board (CSAB).

Note: Numerical figures and product-performance claims in this assignment are reported as they appeared in the webinar slides.

WEBINAR SUMMARY REPORT

1. Introduction and Webinar Context

This webinar was about making better and safer publishing decisions. What stood out to me was that the speakers did not treat predatory publishing as a simple "good journal versus bad journal" problem. Instead, they showed how trust in scholarly publishing depends on several layers: the journal, its editors and publisher, the peer-review process, the authors, and even the way research metrics are interpreted. The webinar then connected these ideas with how Scopus selects, monitors, and re-evaluates sources, and how its tools can support researchers throughout the research lifecycle.

Why predatory publishing is increasing

The opening section explained that publication malpractice is encouraged by "publish or perish" pressure, the ease of setting up professional-looking websites, mass email solicitation, electronic payment systems, lack of publishing experience, and misuse of the open-access model. These conditions make it easier for low-quality or deceptive publishers to attract researchers.

Why choosing the right journal matters?

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

Publishing good work in the wrong journal can lead to loss of money, reputational harm, poor visibility, negative effects on research assessment, uncertain long-term availability of the article, possible delisting from indexing services, and even legal complications. The main lesson was that journal selection is part of responsible research practice, not just an administrative step.

A practical first check before submission

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

Authors were encouraged to ask whether a journal really fits the topic and article type, whether it reaches the intended research community, whether it has a reasonable chance of acceptance, whether it is indexed in relevant databases, and whether its overall practices appear trustworthy. The "Think. Check. Submit." approach was highlighted as a useful way to slow down and verify these points before submitting.

2. Scopus as a Curated Research Database

What Scopus is intended to do

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

Scopus was presented as a large, publisher-neutral, curated indexing database designed to support evidence-based decisions in research. The webinar emphasized broad bibliographic coverage, multiple research metrics, and representation across countries and disciplines. The basic idea is that a curated dataset is more useful for research evaluation than an unfiltered collection of publications.

Independent expert curation through the CSAB

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The Content Selection and Advisory Board (CSAB) was introduced as an independent international board of subject experts. The board includes 17 subject chairs, and many members have journal-editor

experience. Its role is to evaluate eligible journals using structured criteria rather than allowing inclusion to depend only on publisher claims or popularity.

The scope of Scopus authority

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Scopus can decide whether a journal is included, monitored, re-evaluated, or discontinued at the journal level. However, it does not control individual editorial decisions, authorship, the scientific content of every paper, or misconduct investigations inside each article. This distinction was important because indexing can support quality control, but it cannot replace the responsibility of journals, editors, reviewers, and authors.

3. How Scopus Selects Journals

Minimum requirements before review

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Before a title can be considered for Scopus review, the slides listed minimum conditions such as a publication history, peer review, English-language titles and abstracts, a regular publication schedule, and a publication-ethics statement. These are entry conditions; they do not by themselves guarantee acceptance.

Broader selection criteria

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Eligible titles are then examined across journal policy, quality of content, journal standing, regular publication, and online availability. Within those areas, reviewers look at factors such as the type of peer review, editorial and author geography, academic contribution, clarity and readability, consistency with aims and scope, citation patterns, editor standing, timeliness of publication, and the quality and transparency of the journal website.

Aims, scope, ethics, and AI policies

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

A journal should have a clear reason to exist and a scope that is specific enough to guide authors and readers. The webinar warned that vague or extremely broad aims can be a concern. It also stressed that publication-ethics policies are increasingly important and that journals now need clear positions on the responsible use of AI.

Editorial-board and geographic credibility

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

The composition of the editorial board should make sense for the journal’s subject and claimed reach. For example, a journal calling itself “international” should normally show genuine international participation in its scope, editors, or authors. At the same time, the speaker noted that regional journals can be valuable when their identity and audience are represented honestly.

Peer-review warning signs

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Suspicious signals include an unclear review process, unusually fast or guaranteed review times, dependence on a single editor or reviewer, difficulty attracting suitable referees, biased reviewers, weak identity checks, rapid unexplained growth in publication volume, or cases where authors influence or manipulate their own review. Peer review was presented as one of the strongest practical indicators of journal quality.

4. Research Integrity and Predatory Practices

Retractions need context

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

The webinar showed both the absolute number of retractions by country and the proportion of retractions relative to publication output. This was a useful reminder that raw counts can be misleading. A country with more publications may naturally have more retractions in absolute numbers, so interpretation should consider scale, field, and context.

Layers of risk

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Research-integrity problems were presented as a set of connected layers: authors, manuscripts, journals, editors or editorial boards, publishers, and owners. This model helped show why one suspicious article does not automatically prove that an entire journal is predatory, and why journal-level problems can exist even when some individual articles are genuine. The speaker summarized the approach as combining journal-integrity indicators with contextual evidence.

Types of integrity breaches

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Examples included owner malpractice, publishers acting as editors, quiet takeovers of existing titles, scope changes after ownership changes, inter-publisher collusion, reviewer or citation cartels, and journal hijacking. These examples showed that publication fraud can be organized and can involve several actors at the same time.

Paper mills, predatory journals, and hijacked journals

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

The webinar drew a useful distinction between three threats. Paper mills may fabricate research, authorship, or citations for payment. Predatory journals may accept poor or fake work with inadequate peer review in exchange for fees. Hijacked journals imitate the identity of legitimate journals and use that reputation to deceive authors. Financial incentives and pressure for better research metrics were identified as common drivers.

Shared responsibility for trustworthy research

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

Authors were asked to be transparent about funding, conflicts, authorship, data, and AI use; reviewers should test whether claims are supported and report integrity concerns; and editors should create clear policies, protect review independence, screen for problems, and correct the literature when necessary. One of the most human messages in the webinar was that integrity is not about never making mistakes, but about making research transparent, scrutinizable, and correctable.

5. Continuous Monitoring and Re-evaluation in Scopus

Indexing is not permanent certification

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

A major point was that a journal may meet the standards when it enters Scopus and later change. Ownership, scope, editorial leadership, publication volume, or integrity practices can deteriorate. Therefore, authors should not assume that a journal is safe simply because older issues appear in Scopus.

Monitor → Flag → Curate

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

The re-evaluation process was described as a cycle. Scopus monitors titles for unusual behaviour and community concerns, checks possible integrity violations, and watches changes such as transfers of ownership, title or scope changes, and new editorial boards. If needed, a journal can be flagged, coverage can be placed on hold, and the CSAB can decide whether coverage should continue or be discontinued.

Re-evaluation results shown in the webinar

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

The slides reported that in 2024, 114 titles were re-evaluated: 46 continued and 68 were discontinued. For 2025, 108 titles were shown as re-evaluated: 12 continued and 94 were discontinued. Since 2016, the webinar reported 1,335 re-evaluations, with 787 titles (59%) discontinued, plus 127 cases in which coverage was stopped because of authenticity concerns. These figures were presented to show that curation continues after initial acceptance.

Practical warnings to authors

Presented by: Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna

The speaker advised researchers to watch for false or misleading information, lack of transparency, aggressive solicitation, suspicious topic or authorship drift, and journal clones using different URLs. Authors were strongly advised to submit through the authentic journal, avoid intermediaries who promise publication, and remember that no third party can legitimately guarantee acceptance or Scopus indexing. Buying or selling authorship was clearly described as unethical.

6. CSAB Expert Perspective: How a Journal Is Judged in Practice

The second half of the journal-evaluation discussion became more practical when Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen, a CSAB Subject Chair in Agriculture and Biological Sciences and Editor-in-Chief of Geoderma, explained how he thinks about real journals. His examples showed why a checklist is useful, but also why judgement and context still matter.

Why Scopus and the CSAB are needed

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

The CSAB acts both as a gatekeeper for new journals and as an ongoing quality-control mechanism for journals that are already indexed. This is especially important because journals can change after acceptance, and because a professional website or recognizable authors are not enough to establish trustworthiness.

Case example: Journal A

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

Journal A was described as India-based, around two years old, professionally designed, and publishing papers by seemingly impressive international authors. The example was used to show that outward appearance can create a strong first impression, but that deeper checks are still necessary.

Case example: Journal B

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

A systematic review by an established senior author reportedly contained 37 fake references out of 43 cited references. The concern had been raised with the publisher or editor, but the paper was still online at the time shown in the webinar. The lesson was that senior authorship and a formal-looking article cannot substitute for checking the actual content and references.

Case example: Journal C

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

This journal reportedly began publishing many articles that were wildly outside its original scope in 2025, after which Scopus indexing was discontinued. It was a clear example of why a journal's current behaviour matters more than its historical reputation alone.

Does the journal "make sense"?

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

A practical evaluation starts with coherence: Is the scope clearly formulated? Does the title fit that scope? Does the editorial team have the right subject expertise and geographical distribution? Do the published articles match the stated topics and audience? These questions help detect journals whose identity is inconsistent with what they actually publish.

Journal standing and editorial credibility

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

The expert suggested looking at whether the editor-in-chief has the right expertise, is actively publishing, has an appropriate publication and citation record, and is free from obvious scientific-

misconduct concerns. The broader journal can also be checked for links to problematic actors, ethical retractions, and discussion on platforms such as PubPeer.

Quality of published content

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

Article quality can be judged through clarity of abstracts, readability, citation trends, excessive self-citation, dominance by a small group of authors or editors, and the quality of English abstracts or captions when the main language is not English. The journal should also occupy a plausible niche and be able to maintain a stable, reasonable publication volume.

Observations from reviewing some Indian and Pakistani journals

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

The presenter said that, in journals he had reviewed, he had sometimes encountered very fast peer review, questionable publishers, famous names listed on editorial boards without clear awareness, editors who were difficult to identify, retractions or PubPeer concerns, and journals claiming to be international while having a mainly local author or editor base. He also stated that there is significant room to improve process quality. I understood this as his experience with particular journals, not as a general judgement about all journals from those countries.

Practical advice for authors choosing a journal

Presented by: Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen

His advice was to be conservative when possible: established, trusted journals with current Scopus coverage are usually a safer option. New journals can still be valuable, especially in the Global South, but authors should read their recent papers, check publisher reputation, look for PubPeer or Retraction Watch discussions, ask colleagues, and verify that people listed as editors are real scholars who are genuinely connected to the journal.

7. Scopus Beyond Indexing: Discovery, Metrics, and Research Assessment

Benefits across the research lifecycle

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

Scopus was presented as useful beyond journal checking. The slides described uses in literature review, multidisciplinary discovery, identifying research opportunities, avoiding duplication, finding funding information, deciding where to publish, identifying collaborators, monitoring research impact, and supporting career development.

Global disciplinary coverage

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The webinar showed broad subject coverage, with figures current as of February 2026: 10,481 Physical Sciences titles, 8,219 Health Sciences titles, 13,755 Social Sciences titles, and 5,765 Life Sciences titles. The larger point was that Scopus aims to support discovery across disciplines rather than operate as a narrow subject database.

Two rules for responsible use of metrics

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The presenter emphasized two simple rules: do not rely on only one research metric as the quantitative input, and combine quantitative indicators with qualitative judgement. This matched the earlier message about journal integrity: a single number rarely tells the whole story.

Document-level metrics

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

At the article level, Scopus can show citation overviews, citation counts, graphs, comparisons, and links to citing documents. The slides also described PlumX-style engagement categories such as usage, captures, mentions, social-media activity, and citations, giving a broader view of how a research output is being used or discussed.

Journal-level metrics

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The webinar introduced CiteScore, SNIP, and SJR. CiteScore measures citation impact using Scopus data. SNIP adjusts for different citation behaviour across subject fields, so a citation can have different weight depending on the field. SJR incorporates the prestige and subject context of citations and can be applied to journals, book series, and conference proceedings.

Author and organization information

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

Scopus author profiles can be used to follow an individual researcher's citation history, publication counts, citation counts, h-index, co-author information, and trends over time. Organization profiles allow users to search affiliations and review an institution's research output, authors, subject distribution, and related indicators.

8. AI for Research and Scopus AI

Why general-purpose AI may not be enough for research

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The webinar argued that research decisions require extra care because general-purpose AI can produce inaccurate outputs, offer weak domain depth, create privacy or intellectual-property concerns, and provide references that cannot be verified. One slide reported that 71% of people may lose trust after inaccurate outputs; the broader point was that untrusted AI is risky when decisions depend on evidence.

Responsible Scopus AI features presented

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

Scopus AI was described as using vector search over more than 120 million vectorized abstracts, a RefChecker that verifies claims against source documents, a transparent copilot that shows how queries are processed, a confidence system, bias and hallucination mitigation, and privacy protections. The slide also displayed internal performance figures such as a 98% entailment rate, 89% user trust rate, and 96% ethics pass rate; these numbers are recorded here as webinar claims.

AI capabilities demonstrated

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The available research functions shown in the webinar included a referenced summary, expanded summary, concept map, emerging themes, deeper follow-up questions, identification of topic experts, foundational documents, conversational follow-up, and a multi-page deep research report. These tools were positioned as a way to move from a broad question to more structured exploration of the literature.

Checking current Scopus coverage

Presented by: Dr. Shubhra Dutta

The final practical slide showed that researchers can use the official Scopus content and Source List pages to verify titles. The list includes journals and books, and discontinued sources can also be checked. The webinar noted that the discontinued-source file is updated regularly and provided a re-evaluation contact for publication concerns.

9. My Main Takeaways

After going through the full webinar, I felt that the most useful part was how the speakers connected publishing ethics with everyday decisions that researchers actually make. The topic was not only "avoid fake journals." It was really about learning how to judge evidence, people, processes, and metrics together.

No.	Takeaway	Presenter(s)
1	A professional website, famous name, or impressive metric is not enough to prove that a journal is trustworthy.	Dr. Shubhra Dutta / Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen
2	Scopus indexing is useful evidence, but authors should check the journal's current status because coverage can later be discontinued.	Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna
3	Journal quality should be judged from several signals: scope, editorial credibility, peer review, published content, ethics, citation behaviour, and external reputation.	Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna / Prof. Dr. Jan Willem van Groeningen
4	Predatory publishing includes more than low-quality journals; paper mills, hijacked journals, citation manipulation, and ownership changes can also threaten research integrity.	Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna
5	Research integrity is shared. Authors, reviewers, editors, publishers, and indexing services each have different responsibilities.	Dr. Gowri Gopalakrishna
6	Metrics and AI can support better decisions, but they should not replace human judgement or source verification.	Dr. Shubhra Dutta

10. Conclusion

The webinar gave a balanced picture of scholarly publishing. Scopus can reduce risk by using expert selection, broad metadata, metrics, and continuous monitoring, but it is not a substitute for researchers checking journals themselves. For me, the clearest lesson is to verify a journal from multiple directions before submitting: check what it claims, check who runs it, check what it actually publishes, and check

its current indexing status. The same careful mindset should be used with research metrics and AI tools. They are most useful when they support informed judgement rather than becoming shortcuts for it.